

Home

Library

Profile

Stories

Stats

Following

Dev Genius

Python in Plain En...

Generative AI

Realworld AI Use C...

The Useful Tech

Level Up Coding

AI Mind

Deep concept

Top Python Librari...

The Mac Alchemist

More

Write A Catalyst

Member-only story

6 Free AI Tools That Replace \$500/Month Subscriptions

I cancelled every paid AI subscription I had. Six months later, my work quality actually improved. Here's what I replaced them with.



Suraj Jha

Follow

5 min read · May 6, 2026



369



6



2



6 Free AI Tools

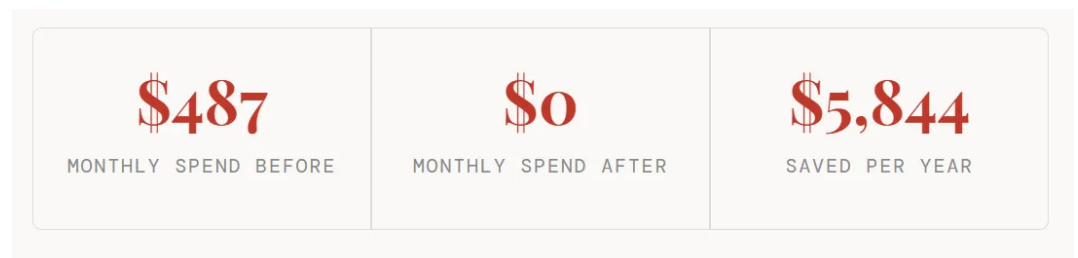
This march, I opened my debit card statement and felt sick. \$487 every month on AI subscriptions.

Jasper, Midjourney, Grammarly, Synthesia, Otter.ai, Copy.ai — I told myself they were all “necessary.” But reality is, I had just stopped questioning the cost.

So, I decided to run a 30-day experiment: In this I plan to replace every paid AI tool with a free alternative.

In the Beginning, I expected free tools to be worse. Some were. But seven of them were actually better than the paid versions I was using.

By the end of the month:



That's when I realized something:

Most people are still paying out of habit, not necessity.

We all are familiar with Jasper. It built its reputation as AI tool for marketers

It cost around \$59/month, and gives you templates, workflows, and brand voice features.

But after testing it for 30 days, I realized: Claude could do almost everything Jasper promised — for free.

- Blog posts
- Email campaigns
- Ad copy
- Product descriptions
- Even long-form content ideas.

In most cases, Claude's writing felt more natural and more detailed

The biggest difference?

Jasper makes you work through templates. But Claude just asks you to explain what you want.

And honestly, that simplicity made me faster.

Midjourney is powerful tool for creating cinematic, artistic images.

But most people don't actually need digital masterpieces for daily work.

You need simple, clean visuals for social posts, presentations, blog banners, and ads. That's where Canva surprised me.

And unlike Midjourney, the images were already inside my design workspace.

- No Discord servers.
- No complicated prompting.
- No downloading and uploading files again and again.

That convenience alone saved me hours of handwork.

For image generation, you can also use ChatGPT's free DALL·E — especially for text, logos, and product-style images where Midjourney still struggles sometimes.

For real-world content creation?

Canva + DALL·E covered almost everything for free.

Synthesia is not doubt the best AI video creation tool.

For \$67/month, you get AI avatar videos that look professional.

But after using it for a quite some time, I realized: Most people don't actually need AI avatars.

They just need fast videos for YouTube, social media, presentations, product demos, or training content.

That's where I add InVideo in my list, and i have to say it became a surprisingly good replacement.

You paste a script, and it automatically creates a video with stock footage, captions, transitions, and AI voiceovers.

The free plan has limits and watermarks, yes.

But for occasional videos, it's more than enough.

This was the hardest subscription for me to cancel.

I used Grammarly Premium every single day, and for a long time.

Mostly for my writing tasks.

But after testing it honestly, I realized: The free version already fixes most real writing mistakes.

- Grammar errors.
- Spelling.
- Basic clarity issues.

That's probably 80% of what most people actually need.

So, I changed my workflow.

First, I run my writing through Grammarly Free. Then I paste the final draft into Claude and ask:

"Polish this for clarity and tighten every paragraph without changing my voice."

The output is consistently better.

- More natural.
- More context aware.
- Less robotic.

I also started using the free Hemingway App to work on passive voice and overly complex sentences.

This was the easiest replacement on the entire list.

I must say Fathom didn't just replace Otter.ai Pro — it completely outperformed it.

It connects with Zoom, Google Meet, and Teams, records meetings, creates accurate transcripts, and automatically generates summaries with action items.

Usually, free tools come with obvious compromises. Fathom didn't feel like a compromise at all.

The free version is simply better.

I don't realize how much time I wasted on research.

Not just searching Google — but opening 30+ tabs, checking each source manually, and trying to figure out which site is actually trustworthy.

That's why Perplexity became one of the most valuable free tools I ever tried.

It searches the live web, summarizes information in real time, and — most importantly — cites its sources directly inside the answer.

The best way to describe it?

It's like Google and ChatGPT had a smarter, more organized child.

And for most daily research work, the free plan is more than enough.

The Full Picture: What You're Actually Replacing

This month, my AI subscription bill was exactly \$0.

And strangely enough, my productivity didn't collapse.

It improved.

The real lesson from this experiment: AI became cheap faster than people realized.

And many of us kept paying old prices simply out of habit.

Thanks for reading,
Suraj...

Enjoyed the read?
Your support means a lot and helps others find this piece, too.

Buy Me A Coffee

- Technology
- Artificial Intelligence
- Programming
- Data Science
- Productivity

Published in Write A Catalyst

204K followers · Last published just now

Write A Catalyst and Build it into Existence.

Follow

Written by Suraj Jha

967 followers · 54 following

A guy with bad writing skill and still posting LOL

Follow
